limited but more feasible goal would be harder to attain if Sino-Indian relations were bad.

Nehru did not think there would be any real Chinese military invasion of India in the "foreseeable future." For one, this would likely spark a world war. Also, Beijing needed to defend its other borders and would hardly be able to divert the troops required for a major attack on India. However, "gradual infiltration" across the border and Chinese occupation of disputed territory was possible—and indeed a risk. This required improving connectivity to India's tribal areas in the northeast, which were not well integrated with the country, and preparation to prevent any Chinese infiltration. Furthermore, India needed to tackle the other real threat from China—the "infiltration of … ideas"—with ideas of its own.

The Indian prime minister believed that visible military strengthening on the scale that Patel envisioned was neither desirable nor feasible. Any attempt to build up India's military on the Sino-Indian border would likely reinforce Chinese insecurity and be counterproductive—such preparation would serve as a provocation rather than a deterrent. Furthermore, Nehru asserted that India did not have the financial and military resources to prepare for an unlikely attack. Diverting significant resources to the Sino-Indian border would also undermine Indian defence vis-à-vis Pakistan, which he saw as the major potential threat. He believed, additionally, that Pakistan would take political or military advantage of Sino-Indian tensions. Even if India enhanced its defense capabilities or looked abroad for military supplies, it would then be left in a strategically "unsound" position with two major enemies.

Nehru did not rule out the possibility that the Chinese communists would be expansionist, but he did not believe this was inevitable. It depended on a number of factors, including the development of both countries and the extent to which China adopted communist characteristics. Sino-Indian conflict would be mutually destructive and would allow external actors to take advantage. Given this assessment and the level of India's capabilities, while Delhi should prepare for contingencies, Nehru continued to believe that the best approach was reaching "some kind of understanding" with China, as long as Beijing desired the same.[177] This belief underlay India's subsequent Tibet and China policy.